Audio file

Teams and Teamwork.m4a

Transcript

Welcome to this video in this series, Entrepreneurship in Action. My name is Anna-Sophie Ulferblank and I'm an assistant professor at the Department of Industrial Engineering and Innovation Sciences. In today's video, we'll be talking about teamwork. When we think of the typical entrepreneur, we often have this inspirational individual in mind. But in reality, this is often not the case. Successful startups like Ben and Jerry's or Apple were initially founded by teams. Often they were childhood friends or they met during summer jobs. But what are teams? Why do we need teams? And what makes teams innovative? These are questions that we will be answering in this video. Literature provides us with a very clear answer, but you might already have a feeling of, when you look at the pictures below, which one is a team and which one is not. In the literature we say a team consists of two or more team members that socially interact, that could be virtually, or face-to-face that are interdependent, that means they depend on each other in fulfilling their goals, have a common purpose or goal, and often have different roles and responsibilities within the team. We often use teamwork when we deal with complex or difficult tasks that might also be urgent or where innovation is needed. Also, organizational needs might call for teamwork, for instance, when there are a lot of changes going on or there is uncertainty. When we look at bigger organizations, we often see research and development teams to create innovative products or we see management teams to decide on larger organizational outcomes. Teamwork comes with a lot of benefits because teams can be composed of people with different backgrounds. So we can combine different resources, different perspectives, and ideas can be fertilized across team members. While this might be common knowledge to you, when we look at organizations, for example, in the 80s, there was a much stronger focus on individual performance. And teamwork was really focused on specific areas, such as sports or military. In today's organizational environments, we have a much stronger focus on innovation or adaptability. So teamwork is becoming even more important than before. But what makes them innovative? and colleagues asked exactly this question and investigated what factors impact the innovativeness of the team. What they found was it really depends on how the team is set up, what processes take place within the team, and the environment in which the team interacts in. For instance, it's extremely important that individuals in the team have goal interdependence. That means I cannot fulfill my goal if my colleague is not fulfilling their goals. This fosters collaboration, communication and interaction with the team. Further, having different perspectives on the team, as we previously mentioned, is extremely important. So job

relevant diversity is a strong predictor of team innovation. For instance, having people with different skills, education or tenure within the organization. Team processes are equally relevant, so having a shared vision, Supporting innovation, so striving for innovation as a team, having a strong task orientation that means having a shared commitment to the vision and a high quality of the ideas you are developing. Further, cohesion is very important that means people within the team are committed to being part of the innovation team. While this is all helpful for innovation, it also really depends on what environment the team is interacting in. An organization, for example, needs to be very supportive of innovation and personal initiative to foster innovation in teams. For instance, if you are very innovative, but the organization doesn't really support your ideas further, this can be very frustrating and demotivating. This is strongly related to psychological safety, which means you feel safe to speak up as a team. This is very important for raising, for example, contradictory opinions or new ideas. And we all know that a devil's advocate can be very helpful for innovation. So to conclude, teamwork can be very beneficial for innovation. However, it really depends on how the team is set up, how the team interacts, and the environment they interact with, whether they are innovative or not. With this, I wish you all the best of luck for your teamwork and thank you for listening to this video.